Westbrook Planning Board

~ Planning Board Meeting ~

Date: Tuesday, August 4, 2026
Time: 7:00 PM
Location: Westbrook High School (Room 114), 125 Stroudwater St. (Hybrid via Zoom)
Video: https://vimeo.com/1215631136
Packet: https://www.westbrookmaine.gov/AgendaCenter/ViewFile/Agenda/_08042026-1020

Timestamps below are clickable [0:00]-style links — they jump straight to that moment in the video.

This summary highlights the meeting's key discussions and decisions, with direct quotes and timestamps for verification — it is not a substitute for watching the full meeting. *All nine seated board members were present. For complete context, nuance, and anything not covered, watch the full video at the link above. (Produced by: WestbrookCurrents.com)*

Regular Business

24-000632 — Site Plan Approval Extension — 4 & 7 Kidder Lane, Quaker Lane Associates [1:32]

Discussion Summary

Craig Burtis (Acorn Engineering) requested a one-year extension of the April 2025 site plan approval (amended September 2025) for the 110-unit mixed-use redevelopment at the end of Kidder Lane, which also includes a westerly extension of the River Walk Trail. Construction is now set to begin this fall under a phased schedule coordinated with the adjacent Saccarappa Park project: Phase 1 covers demolition, utility installation, the main storm drain runs, and replacement of a 48-inch stormwater pipe under Dana Street, now specified in HDPE plastic rather than concrete (lighter, easier to handle, comparable lifespan, lower cost). Erosion control along the Presumpscot River goes in this fall and is re-inspected before Phase 2 (likely spring 2027) tackles the stormwater tree filters, rain garden, and remaining site work.

City Planner Rebecca Spitella explained the phased approach lets the applicant post a smaller performance guarantee for the fall utility/demolition work alone, with the full project guarantee required once Phase 2 begins; no substantive changes were made to the underlying conditions of approval beyond phase-specific triggers.

Vice Chair Turcotte confirmed this is the applicant's first extension request and voiced no objection given the project's size. Nancy Litrocapes, previously recused from this project, asked whether she needed to recuse again for an extension vote; staff advised she could vote if she felt she could remain impartial to the extension itself, and she confirmed support. No public comment.

Key Decisions

✓ Approved 9–0 by roll call, moved by John Turcotte, seconded by Kevin Price.

Action Items

None.

New Business

26-000527 — Site Plan, Final Vote — 3 Saunders Way, Bill Dodge Kia [10:38]

Discussion Summary

Dustin Roma (DM Roma Consulting Engineers) returned with the final site plan for the Bill Dodge Kia renovation first workshopped July 7: a 2,160-sq-ft service-area addition and 3,850-sq-ft showroom addition, updated Kia branding and signage (including a new pylon sign sized to code through Code Enforcement), new EV charging stations, and landscaping improvements at the corner nearest the adjacent Infinity dealership (new trees, shrubs, and perennials replacing a plain grass-and-evergreen strip, to match the Infinity building's more developed landscaping). One existing light pole is removed for the expansion; a second, inside a retained landscaped island, stays. No changes to overall site circulation.

Staff had no additions. Chair McWilliams asked whether the building signage would be illuminated; Roma confirmed internal illumination, useful given early winter darkness, and the Chair called the renovation a nice addition to the corridor. No public comment.

Key Decisions

✓ Approved 9–0 by roll call, moved by John Turcotte, seconded by Karen Axelson.

Action Items

None.

26-000275 — Site Plan, Subdivision, Conditional Use — Marco Commons, 547 Saco St. [19:05]

Discussion Summary

Dustin Roma presented the first phase of “Marco Commons,” subdividing the remaining land at 547 Saco St. (after an existing farmhouse lot was already separated off and donated by the developer to Calvary Church, which uses it as a residential facility for a faith-based recovery program — staff confirmed it does not meet the state's definition of a licensed treatment facility) into three new lots: Lot 1 (a tight envelope reserved for a possible future single-family home around an existing barn), Lot 2 (sized for a future duplex), and Lot 3, the subject of tonight's site plan — two 12-unit multifamily buildings, moved as far as possible from the southern property line to preserve more of the existing tree buffer. All three lots share one private driveway off Saco Street.

An informational master plan shown for context (not for approval) depicts an eventual full build-out of seven 12-unit buildings — 84 total units — at roughly two buildings per year. A roughly 1,300-foot Saco Street sidewalk extension, crosswalk, rapid-flashing beacon, and curbing (ahead of a paving moratorium) are being installed now; the city agreed to separately negotiate the private easements the full sidewalk eventually needs. The Recreation and Conservation Commission accepted this sidewalk work plus an internal trail loop as satisfying the open-space requirement; staff recommended against a public trail connection through the private development, citing recurring conflict elsewhere in the city when that's been tried.

Key Decisions

✓ Approved 9–0 by roll call (subdivision and Lot 3 site plan for two 12-unit buildings), moved by John Turcotte, seconded by Robin Tannenbaum. The board separately voted 9–0 to move into workshop session for the remaining agenda items.

Action Items

None.

Point / Counterpoint

> *“I believe we've heard 184 planned units out back ... I'm sure everybody can do the math and figure out they're gonna be equal or more than those numbers of vehicles entering and leaving Saco Street.”*

— Kathy Gorham, 521 Saco St. abutter (49-year resident) [36:53]

> *“Is that it's not 184, it's 84. There's seven, seven twelve-unit buildings. The full build out, the full master plan [is] 84.”*

— Rebecca Spitella, City Planner (correcting the record) [1:01:53]

> *“Respectfully, saying that a one-bedroom apartment is going to be cheaper than a two-bedroom apartment is not affordable housing ... I expect that these one bedrooms will be at least $2,000 a month for rent, and that's simply not affordable.”*

— Oriana Farnham, Board Member [50:40]

> *“If you rotated building A 180 degrees [to put] the shed in the back, and building B rotated at ninety degrees clockwise ... it would look like two different buildings, but it's the same building.”*

— Jason Frazier, Board Member (on the mechanical sheds facing the lot) [55:36]

Workshop

26-000635 — Site Plan — 100 Larrabee Road, 100 Larrabee LLC [1:07:11]

Discussion Summary

Henry Hess (Sebago Technics) presented a 33–34-space parking expansion at the Larrabee Complex (currently 333 spaces), driven by new tenant leases and recent evening programming that has created congestion. Most new spaces go in along the western Terminal Street side via a shifted driveway entrance, with a new one-way directional pattern near the rear drop-off area intended to reduce crisscrossing traffic at peak times (tied by several board members to a tenant dance studio's evening classes). The roughly 6,000-sq-ft paving expansion requires two new stormwater detention basins and removes four or five existing trees, to be replaced as the formal site plan develops.

The expansion drops the site's landscaped-area percentage from an already-nonconforming 14% to 12%, against the Gateway Commercial District's 25% standard. Staff explained the district allows this if the board finds no reasonable alternative, triggering a fee-in-lieu payment (same formula as the open-space fee-in-lieu, directed to Main Street corridor safety/beautification improvements) preliminarily estimated at about $13,071, pending a finalized number.

An unresolved Fire Department objection: the staff memo flagged that several proposed spaces in front of a building entrance are not supported by the Fire Department on life-safety grounds; staff confirmed the board generally follows Fire Department guidance, and the applicant acknowledged the concern will be addressed before a formal site plan. Member Jason Frazier suggested swapping underused Larrabee Road frontage parking for landscaping, shifting that capacity to the rear. Chair McWilliams proposed that fee-in-lieu funds from projects like this be earmarked for a dedicated tree/landscaping fund rather than a general appearance fund. No public comment.

Key Decisions

✓ No vote — workshop item.

Action Items

None.

Point / Counterpoint

> *“As someone who's cut it a little close on dropping off a daughter at a dance [class] ... you have people leaving and coming at the same time. Circulation is a challenge ... it's been more than once of like, nope, you can't run in, stop, car.”*

— John Turcotte, Vice Chair (on dance-studio pickup/dropoff congestion) [1:16:13]

26-000630 — Site Plan, Subdivision — 267 Conant Street, MGM Builders [1:21:56]

Discussion Summary

Dustin Roma reintroduced a property last brought before the board roughly five to six years ago as an all-commercial development that stalled before final approval due to a paving moratorium conflict. The revived concept proposes three multifamily buildings totaling 36 units, plus a 4,000-sq-ft pad site reserved for a future commercial building (no tenant yet identified) along Conant Street, with a “main street”-style storefront appearance, ample landscaped setback, and parking kept behind all structures. Staff noted the property, previously thought split-zoned, was fully reclassified into the City Center district in an earlier board-initiated rezoning cleanup, giving the applicant more flexibility to reposition buildings than the original stalled plan assumed. The project extends the Conant Street sidewalk east to connect with an adjacent condo development's own recent extension.

Several board members raised concerns about the heavy, undifferentiated parking area and the lack of visual relationship between the two residential buildings, and encouraged the applicant to continue refining the layout before returning (hoped for September 2026) with a full application. No public comment.

Key Decisions

✓ No vote — workshop item.

Action Items

None.

Point / Counterpoint

> *“I find this a tough one to lay out ... you talked about that heavy parking area ... it's very not residential ... I wonder if there's more work that can be done to separate the residential component from the commercial component ... to make it feel residential.”*

— Robin Tannenbaum, Board Member [1:31:01]

> *“I believe we have to have businesses who face the road ... that look at least look like the front of the building ... [but] as long as you make an effort at that look ... I think that's gonna be a good look from Conant Street.”*

— John Turcotte, Vice Chair [1:34:18]

26-000636 — Subdivision — 108 Longfellow Street, Longfellow 108 LLC [1:40:24]

Discussion Summary

Dustin Roma presented a straightforward three-lot subdivision of a 1.7-acre parcel with no physical development proposed at this stage. The existing three-unit multifamily building's driveway easement would be conveyed in fee to the eventual owner of the adjacent, currently undeveloped lot (zoning capacity for roughly nine units under current rules, use undetermined), so that owner can improve shared access on its own land. The lot nearest the steep slope above an abutting property was deliberately drawn with a small building envelope sized only for a single-family home; any development beyond that, or of three or more units on the other lot, would require a separate surface drainage plan review and, for anything of three-plus units, a return trip to this board.

Abutters Larry Mac and Marshall Mac (Mac Brothers, whose family property includes a 90-unit elderly-housing project and a historic building nearby) raised drainage concerns rooted in the site's history (the back road follows a former canal) and high water table, and asked that any future development account for added runoff onto their property. Staff confirmed any future lot development must go through surface drainage plan review and confirmed the small lot meets minimum zoning dimension standards. Chair McWilliams separately flagged a resident's written concern about invasive Japanese knotweed on the site for attention whenever future development occurs.

Key Decisions

✓ No vote — workshop item.

Action Items

None.

Point / Counterpoint

> *“We have a 90-unit [elderly] housing project ... and uh that our back road there was actually the canal ... it's a high water table, the whole area down below ... as far as Area three, I don't have a problem with that ... but area one especially is a problem for us. So that needs to be addressed.”*

— Marshall Mac, abutting property owner (Mac Brothers) [1:49:44]

How this was made

This summary was produced from the meeting video (linked above, hosted on the City's Vimeo showcase). The audio was downloaded with Downie 4 and transcribed with speaker diarization using MacWhisper. Claude (Anthropic's AI) cross-checked names against the official Planning Board roster, attributed speakers from context (introductions, roll-call order, direct address by the Chair) rather than the raw diarization labels alone, and drafted this summary and the quoted excerpts. Quotes are lightly cleaned of filler words/false starts but not reworded. Review tier: Not reviewed.

Produced by Westbrook Currents — westbrookcurrents.com